

The Carpenter's Village: Mio and the Road to Steveston

In 1888 a carpenter named Kuno Gihei left this fishing village for an undeveloped settlement on Canada's Fraser River. He himself found little but hardship there. The neighbors who followed him into salmon fishing did not: within decades Mio's houses, its school and even its nickname, America Village, bore the marks of Steveston's money. This dossier follows both shores.



三尾・アメリカ村（和歌山県美浜町）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (5 chapters, about 900 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A fishing village with little land

Mio sits on the Kii Peninsula, on a stretch of the Hidaka District coast where mountains leave little flat ground and most of the district's harbors open southwest into the Kii Channel. A 1923 geography of the prefecture describes nearby Hii and Yura as deep, sheltered bays, if cramped, and the cape further southwest, Hinomisaki, as a place that gave passing ships' passengers trouble in rough water, marked by that time with a white, rotating lighthouse beam. An Edo-period survey of the same coast describes the villages of the old Mio estate, of which Mio itself was the namesake settlement, as living chiefly by fishing or by carrying cargo in all directions, with no want of a livelihood, in contrast to an inland neighboring estate whose people worked the land instead.²³

The carpenter who went to look for work

The district's own 1923 history sets down what happened next, and who came first. Three other Hidaka villagers had already gone abroad: a man from Yura to the United States and one from Yoshiwara to Hawaii, both in 1885, and one from a hamlet of Hiizaki to British Canada in 1887. Behind them, 'a bit later,' came Kuno Gihei of Mio, a carpenter by trade. He had heard that the Vancouver area of British Canada was promising for fishing, farming and manufacturing; he obtained a travel permit from Kanagawa Prefecture in September 1887 and sailed the following March. He meant to work in industry, but the place he reached, the gazetteer says, was still an undeveloped small settlement, nothing like what he had expected, and he spent more than twenty hard years there.¹

Kuno himself never made much of a success of it. He returned to Japan in December 1911 and died of illness in August 1916, at 63. Yet the same source is direct about his significance: whatever his own fortunes, it says, Mio villagers' later development in North America owed itself largely to him as its spark. The following year, 1889, several more men left, not as general laborers but specifically to fish: Tsuchiyama Torakichi, Mizuyabu Wakamatsu, Kuroyama Yonekichi, Yamamoto Fukumatsu, Yoshida Kamekichi, Osawa Yaichi, Ueda Itaro and others. The waters were rich, the district history notes, but their boats and gear were not equal to it at first; they adapted, did well, and the reports that reached Mio each year drew more of its people after them.¹

Steveston, and the war that scattered it

The place Kuno Gihei and his neighbors were making for is known today as Steveston, a fishing settlement at the mouth of the Fraser River, now part of Richmond, British Columbia. The Canadian side's own account of the connection puts more than 2,000 people of Mio origin living in Canada by 1940, and states that Steveston once held the largest Japanese population anywhere in the country. The pace of the work bred its own speech: fishermen coordinating a salmon run, with no time to be diplomatic, developed what has since been called the Steveston, or Kishu, dialect, remembered today in working terms like 'ajiro' for a good fishing spot.⁸¹¹

The Pacific war broke the pattern. From 1942 the Canadian government removed everyone of Japanese descent from a zone within a hundred miles of the British Columbia coast, roughly 22,000 people in all, more than half of them Canadian-born; homes, cars and fishing boats were left behind and later sold by the government without their owners' consent. Only in 1949, four years after Japan's surrender, were Japanese Canadians permitted back onto the coast and given the same rights, including the vote, as other citizens.⁹

What the money built

Mio itself changed with the money that came back. By 1909 emigrants in America had contributed more than 10,000 yen, a considerable sum, toward building the village's elementary school at Naka-no-hama, remembered in the district's own history as a memorial to their success abroad. Houses built in a recognizably North American style went up too, among them the one

that stands today as the Canada Museum; there were enough of them that Mio had, by the 1920s, already earned in print the nickname a later reference work still uses: America Village, a fishing settlement, it notes, that sent out an unusual number of overseas emigrants and kept, as a result, its own distinct customs.¹¹⁰

Reading the ground today

The clearest place to see this history today is the Canada Museum, in a two-story wooden house with a hipped, green-tiled roof and white-painted siding, built around 1934 by a Mio family who had themselves worked in Vancouver and later passed to the Noda family. Mihama Town took the building over in 2017, opened it as a museum in July 2018, and had it registered as a national tangible cultural property in 2019. Its adjoining Canada Garden holds a totem pole made in Canada and, since 2022, a bronze statue of Kuno Gihei himself, donated by his own great-grandson on a visit from Vancouver, together with an old Fresnel lens said to come from the Hinomisaki lighthouse down the coast.⁵⁶⁷

A short walk away stands Mio's former elementary school, closed as a school but still in use: a local organization now trains village children to explain the area's history in English, a direct echo of the traffic that once ran the other way, from this coast to the Fraser River. The 1923 district history's account of Kuno Gihei's own hard years, set beside the neighbors who did better than he did, is worth remembering on that walk: the museum and the statue mark a success that was, for its first mover, no success at all.¹⁵

Timeline

Edo period	A domain survey of the coast describes Mio-estate villages living chiefly by fishing and coastal shipping. ²
1885	The first Hidaka District emigration pioneers leave, for the US mainland and for Hawaii. ¹
1887-1888	Kuno Gihei of Mio, a carpenter, obtains a travel permit and sails for the Vancouver area of British Canada. ¹
1889	Several more Mio men follow Kuno, specifically to fish; word of their success draws more each year. ¹
1895	A lighthouse is established at Hinomisaki, the cape near Mio. ¹⁰
1909	Mio emigrants in America fund construction of the village's elementary school, over 10,000 yen. ¹
1916	Kuno Gihei dies in Japan at 63, five years after returning from Canada. ¹
1940	More than 2,000 people of Mio origin are living in Canada, many in the Steveston fishing settlement. ⁸
1942-1949	Japanese Canadians are removed from the British Columbia coast; only in 1949 are they permitted to return with full citizenship rights. ⁹
1954	Mio, Wada and Matsubara villages merge to form Mihama Town. ¹⁰
c. 1934	A Mio family returned from Vancouver builds the house that later becomes the Canada Museum. ⁶
2018-2019	Mihama Town opens the Canada Museum in the restored house (2018) and has it registered as a national tangible cultural property (2019). ⁶⁷
2022	Kuno Gihei's great-grandson donates a bronze statue of him to the museum's Canada Garden. ⁵

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1 Canada Museum (former Noda residence)** カナダミュージアム（旧野田家住宅）. A 1930s house built by a Vancouver-returnee family, mixing Japanese and Western styles; a national tangible cultural property since 2019, now telling Mio's own emigration story.⁵⁶⁷
- 2 Canada Garden** カナダガーデン. Beside the museum: a Canadian-made totem pole, a 2022 bronze statue of Kuno Gihei donated by his great-grandson, and a Fresnel lens said to be from the Hinomisaki lighthouse.⁵
- 3 Former Mio Elementary School** 旧三尾小学校. Closed as a school; its 1909 building was funded partly by Mio emigrants in America, and the site now hosts a program training local children to guide visitors in English.¹⁵
- 4 Mio harbor** 三尾の漁港. The working waterfront of a village whose economy, an Edo-period survey already noted, rested on fishing and coastal shipping long before Canada entered the picture.²
- 5 Hinomisaki** 日ノ御埼. The cape southwest of the village, marked by a lighthouse since the 1890s; a rough stretch of water for passing ships, and the source of the lens now displayed in the Canada Garden.³¹⁰

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2019



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2019 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2019*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

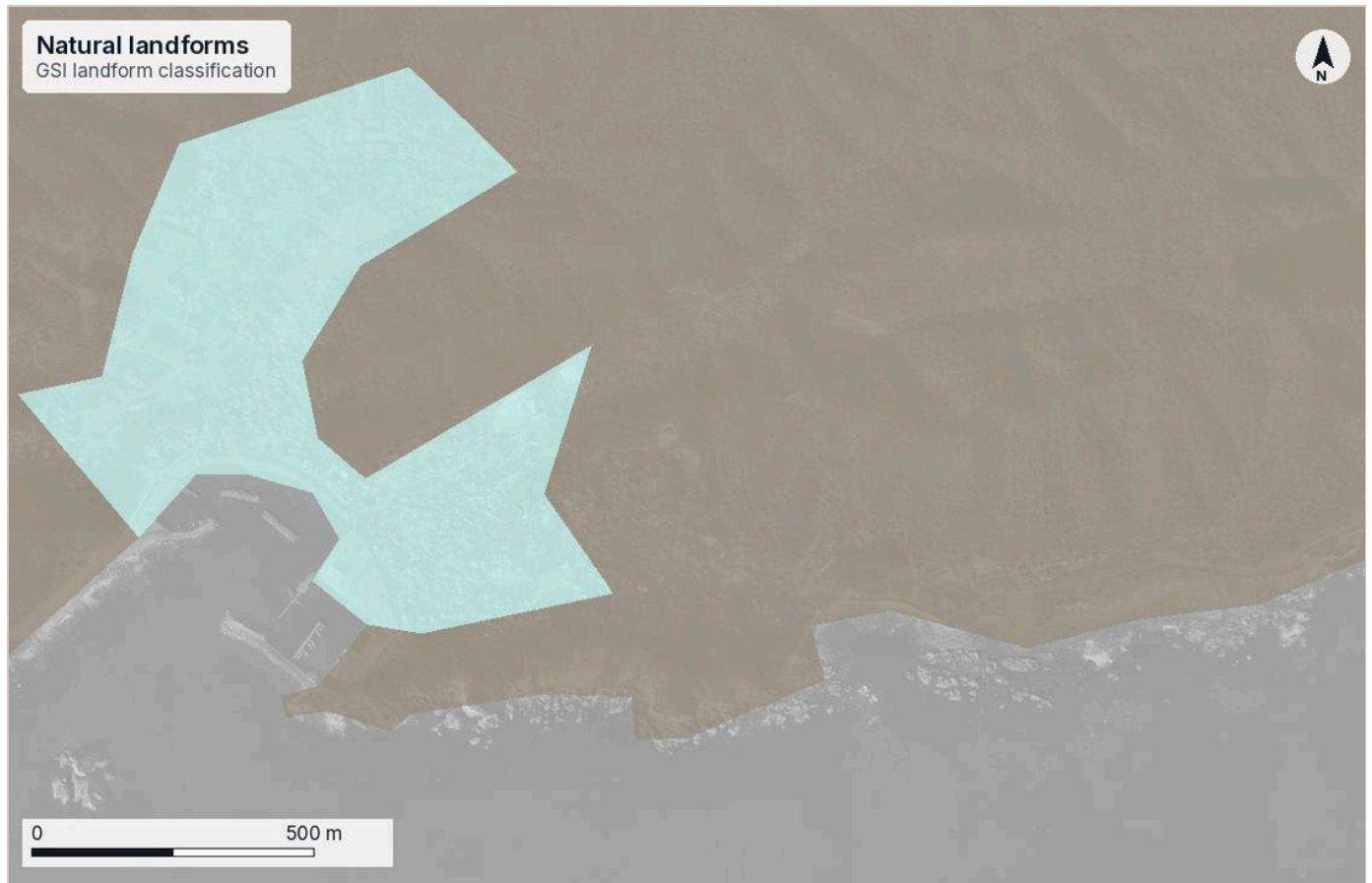
The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Mountains 58%

 Lowland 13%

GSI has no detailed landform survey for this frame, so the map uses GSI's regional classification (compiled for zoom levels 9–13). It shows the broad landform only; former river channels and man-made ground are not mapped at that scale.

What the main landforms mean

Mountains (58%). Terrain of high ridges and valleys. Watch for slope disasters.

Lowland (13%). Flat land built from sand, gravel and mud laid down by rivers or the sea. River flooding, storm surge and liquefaction; shakes easily in earthquakes.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.

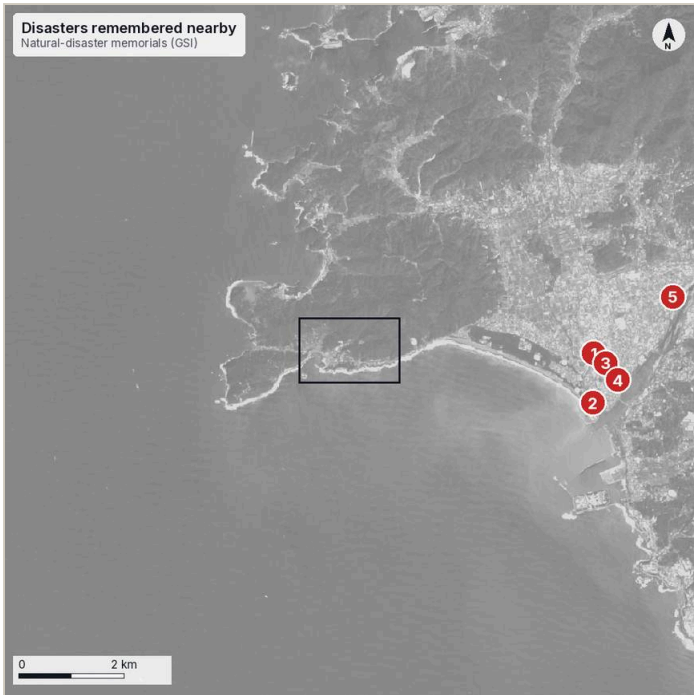
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

GSI has not traced Meiji-era lowland for this frame.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Flood-level marker for the 1953 Kishu flood 水位標	Great Kishu flood (18 Jul 1953) · flood	1958	5.8 km
2 Stone record of the 1854 Ansei Nankai tsunami 津浪之紀事	Ansei Nankai earthquake (24 Dec 1854) · earthquake / tsunami	1862	5.9 km
3 Monument of Murata Yoshinari, recalling the 1889 Hidaka River flood 村田美成の碑	Great Kii Peninsula flood (19–20 Aug 1889) · flood	1894	6.1 km
4 Monument to the 1953 Kishu flood in Gobo 水害之碑	Great Kishu flood (18 Jul 1953) · flood	1954	6.4 km
5 Monument to the restoration of Fujii's farmland after the 1953 Kishu flood 藤井の耕地復旧記念碑	Great Kishu flood (18 Jul 1953) · flood	1962	7.7 km

What the memorials record

1. **Flood-level marker for the 1953 Kishu flood.** The heavy rain of 18 July 1953 broke the embankments; the torrent destroyed hundreds of houses in an instant and laid waste more than 600 hectares of farmland. The marker records the flood level so that the disaster is not forgotten, though it has been moved since it was set up and may no longer show the true level.
2. **Stone record of the 1854 Ansei Nankai tsunami.** The Ansei Nankai earthquake of 24 December 1854 brought a tsunami to Mihama, and people who fled onto the river in boats were sunk by it. The inscription teaches that great earthquakes bring tsunamis and that people should take refuge on the higher ground of the great pine grove.
3. **Monument of Murata Yoshinari, recalling the 1889 Hidaka River flood.** Heavy rain on 19–20 August 1889 broke the embankments of the Hidaka River, and the torrent swept away many houses, people and livestock. The flood is said to have killed 219 people.
4. **Monument to the 1953 Kishu flood in Gobo.** Heavy rain of up to 600 mm on 18 July 1953 made the Hidaka River overflow. Across Gobo City 26 people died, 100 went missing and about 3,000 were injured; an estimated 4,000 houses were flooded above floor level, 365 of them swept away, and recovery took several years. The monument urges future generations never to lose their wariness of nature.
5. **Monument to the restoration of Fujii's farmland after the 1953 Kishu flood.** Heavy rain that had fallen since the night before struck all of Kishu on 18 July 1953, hitting the Arida and Hidaka river basins hardest. Landslides filled valleys, embankments broke, torrents swept away people and houses, and farmland was badly devastated. The monument first stood by the prefectural road at Fujii and now stands on the Gobo–Miyama road at Yoshida.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 和歌山県日高郡 (Hidaka District, Wakayama Prefecture), 和歌山県日高郡誌 [Gazetteer of Hidaka District, Wakayama Prefecture], 1923; NDL frames 147, 148. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/978627/1/147> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The village-by-village account of Meiji-era emigration pioneers, including Kuno Gihei's own story in full detail, his 1889 fishing companions, and the 1909 emigrant-funded school.
2. 仁井田好古 等編 (Niita Yoshihisa and others, eds.), 紀伊続風土記 [Kii Zoku Fudoki (gazetteer of Kii Province), Hidaka District volumes], 1911; NDL frame 309. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/765518/1/309> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The Edo-period description of the old Mio estate's villages as living chiefly by fishing and coastal shipping.
3. 郷土教育研究会 (Local History Education Research Society), 和歌山県地史大観 [A comprehensive view of Wakayama Prefecture's geography and history], 1923; NDL frame 80. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/913259/1/80> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: General description of Hidaka District's coast, harbors and the Hinomisaki cape with its white rotating lighthouse.
4. 和歌山県日高郡 (Hidaka District, Wakayama Prefecture), 和歌山県日高郡統計一斑 明治42年 [A statistical summary of Hidaka District, Wakayama Prefecture, 1909], 1910; NDL frame 11. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/807484/1/11> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Confirms Mio-mura as a separately listed village in the district's own 1910 statistical compilation (its exact population figure could not be read reliably from the scanned table).
5. カナダミュージアム/NPO日ノ岬・アメリカ村 [Canada Museum / NPO Hinomisaki-America Village], NPO法人日ノ岬・アメリカ村 (NPO Hinomisaki-America Village). <https://americamura.wakayama.jp/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The museum's opening (July 2018), the Canada Garden's totem pole, Fresnel lens and 2022 Kuno Gihei statue, and the NPO's base at the former Mio Elementary School with its English-language junior storyteller program.
6. 旧野田家住宅 [The Old Noda Residence], わかやまの文化財 (Wakayama Prefecture cultural properties database). https://wakayama-bunkazai.jp/bunkazai/bunkazai_826/, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Construction around 1934 by a family returned from working in Vancouver; later owned by the Noda family; architectural description; 2019 registration as a national tangible cultural property.
7. 三尾の旧野田家住宅等 国の登録有形文化財に [Mio's Old Noda Residence and related structures become a national Registered Tangible Cultural Property], 日高新報 (Hidaka Shimpō). <https://hidakashimpō.co.jp/?p=32650>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The November 2018 recommendation for registration, and the 2017 transfer of the property from the Noda family to Mihama Town.
8. *Steveston's Connection to Mio* [Steveston's Connection to Mio], Gulf of Georgia Cannery National Historic Site. <https://gulfofgeorgiacannery.org/stevestons-connection-to-mio/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: More than 2,000 people of Mio origin living in Canada by 1940, and Steveston's status as once having the largest Japanese population in Canada.
9. *Japanese Canadian History in Brief* [Japanese Canadian History in Brief], Nikkei National Museum & Cultural Centre. <https://centre.nikkeiplace.org/research/japanese-canadian-history-in-brief/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1942 removal of roughly 22,000 Japanese Canadians from the British Columbia coast, loss of property including boats, and the 1949 restoration of the right to return and to vote.
10. 美浜町 [Mihama-cho (encyclopedia entry, citing Britannica Kokusai Daihyakka Jiten, Nihon Rekishi Chimei Taikei and Digital Daijisen)], コトバンク (Kotobank). <https://kotobank.jp/word/%E7%BE%8E%E6%B5%9C%E7%94%BA-139370>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1954 merger of Mio, Wada and Matsubara into Mihama Town; the 1895 Hinomisaki lighthouse; Mio's 'America Village' nickname and distinct customs.
11. *Mio-Steveston Fishermen Dialect* [Mio-Steveston Fishermen Dialect], Discover Nikkei, Japanese American National Museum. <https://discovernikkei.org/en/journal/2017/2/7/mio-steveston-fishermen-dialect/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Steveston/Kishu fishermen's dialect that developed among Mio-origin fishermen, with example vocabulary.

Further reading

- 美浜町史 下巻 (美浜町史編集委員会編, 1991) — Mihama Town's own official local history; full-text hits on 三尾/アメリカ村 at many frames including 100-102, 171-189, 513-540. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9576634> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- アメリカ村：移民送出村の実態 (福武直編, 1953) — A landmark 1953 sociological field study of Mio as an emigrant-sending village, the basis for much later scholarship. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/2461997> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 海外移民が母村に及ぼした影響：和歌山県日高郡三尾村実態調査 (福武直編, 1953) — A companion survey specifically on emigration's effects on Mio village itself. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/3454243> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- わがルーツ・アメリカ村：老人たちはいま (小山茂春著, 1984) — Oral-history interviews with elderly Mio villagers about the Canada connection. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/11971517> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- カナダ移住百年誌 (カナダ移住百年誌編集委員会編, 1989) — A centennial history of Japanese emigration to Canada with direct treatment of Kuno Gihei and Mio at frames 4-65. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/13106713> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Household-level emigration and remittance records for named Mio families** — Mihama Town's local-history archive and the Japan Overseas Migration Museum (JICA Yokohama). Consult 美浜町史 and the underlying field notes of the 1953 Fukutake surveys (S. Fukutake, アメリカ村 and 海外移民が母村に及ぼした影響) for household-by-household data.
- **Canadian-side immigration, naturalization and fishing-license records for Mio-born residents of Steveston** — Library and Archives Canada, and the Nikkei National Museum & Cultural Centre (Burnaby, BC). Search Library and Archives Canada's immigration records by port and year; the Nikkei museum holds community and fishing-license collections.
- **Records of Japanese Canadian internment specifically affecting Mio-origin families, and any subsequent redress claims** — Landscapes of Injustice project archive (University of Victoria) and the Nikkei National Museum. Search the Landscapes of Injustice online database by family name or by Steveston address.
- **The full run of the Gulf of Georgia Cannery's and Steveston Museum's photographic and oral-history collections on Mio-origin families** — Gulf of Georgia Cannery National Historic Site and Richmond Museum, British Columbia. Contact the cannery's archives directly; many oral histories are catalogued but not yet online.
- **A fuller reading of the classical 紀伊続風土記 entry for Mio itself (the frame read here covers the wider 'Mio estate' rather than the village in isolation)** — National Diet Library Digital Collections, pid 765518, and the Wakayama Prefectural Library's local-history room. Full-text search the same pid for 三尾浦 and 三尾荘 across the whole Hidaka-gun volumes (frames 291-380) and cross-check with a modern annotated edition.

Caveats

- Kuno Gihei's birth year is not stated directly in the source used here; only his death (August 1916, at age 63) is given, so no birth year is asserted in this dossier.
- The Edo-period survey cited for the area's fishing economy describes the medieval 'Mio estate' and several of its constituent hamlets by name; it does not name Mio-ura itself in the specific passage read, so the connection to the village is presented here as reasonably inferred rather than explicitly stated by that source.
- This dossier could not verify a consistent construction date for the Hinomisaki lighthouse: one compiled reference (Kotobank, citing Britannica) gives 1895, while a separate, less reliable fetch produced an internally inconsistent 1873 date; this dossier uses only the 1895 figure and otherwise keeps the lighthouse's history undated.
- Automated summaries of Mio-related web pages twice produced conflicting or garbled personal names for individuals connected to specific historic buildings; where a name could not be independently confirmed, this dossier omits it rather than risk a wrong romanization.
- The official Mihama Town website (town.mihama.wakayama.jp) could not be reached this session; municipal-history facts instead rely on a compiled reference source (Kotobank/Britannica) that names its own underlying references.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition is a draft for testing the product and has not had independent fact-checking.